



JURY REPORT JAN ROËDE AWARD 2026

13 June 2014 marked the 100th anniversary of the birth of visual artist Jan Roëde (1914-2007) from The Hague. To mark the occasion, the board of the Jan Roëde Foundation, founded to manage his artistic legacy, established that year in collaboration with the Royal Academy of Art the Jan Roëde Award, an annual incentive prize for a graduating artist from the KABK's Fine Arts department.

As a token of recognition, the prize aims to encourage the laureate to further develop their talents and skills after graduation and is being awarded for the thirteenth time this year.

The jury for the Jan Roëde Prize 2026 consisted of Lakisha Apostel, Juliette Hengst, Louw van Sinderen, Dick Stapel and Huub van Wersch.

On 3 July 2026, the jury assessed the presentations by 25 students who graduated from the Fine Arts department this year and wanted to be considered for the prize. The jury faced a difficult task, as how to choose from very different projects, each with its own quality and eloquence? At the end of its deliberations, the jury decided to award this year's Jan Roëde Award to

Kimia Khedri

The jury viewed her graduation project '*Something to Hold On*' with fascination and great respect. Khedri, an Iranian artist born in Tehran in 2003, presents a body of work that testifies to a profound artistic urgency. Unbidden, the war in Iran has, in recent months, come to capture her artistic soul – not as a consciously chosen theme, but as a paralysing sense of powerlessness. She herself describes this feeling as having to watch a burning field before you with nothing more in hands than a bowl of water .

To what can one turn for refuge and solace in such a situation? With this question in mind, Khedri created an installation in which stories, images, textiles, text and scent converge. At the heart of the installation is a large wooden cube, which invites to come in. On its exterior,

haunting mixed-media collages confront the viewer with the raw, tactile reality of burning, catastrophe and destruction. Although largely abstract, the tragic contours of reality shine through: two human shadows beneath a battered tree, the debris of a ruin, the charred remains of a desolate world that no longer offers a place for life.

Who enters the cube seems to step into an intimate, sacred inner world. The video presented here envisages the practice of do'a-nevis (Iranian spell-writers and talisman-makers). It shows how, in times of darkness, people try to come to terms with the elusiveness of their fate. They want to act on their pressing desire to turn the tide, to undo the catastrophe, to find something to hold on to. And then there is the fame of this spell-writer in the outskirts of Tehran to whom people can put forward their questions and concerns. People swear by his name. Could he write spells that might bring back to life the 60,000 people who have perished, plus those 182 others, plus that one special person? Spells that turn the red sky blue again or that make the tears that have been shed flow back into the eyes? Spells that make the ground beneath our feet green and full of flowers? Perhaps not straight away, but...

The power of the installation lies in the realisation that both the artworks and the spells are from the outset 'failed dreams'. Neither the imagination embodied in a work of art nor the incantation of a talisman can restore a devastated city or bring back the dead. The work therefore offers no utopian solutions, but stands as a monument to the human refusal to give up. It honours the urge to keep striving for wholeness, even when a resolution is only guaranteed three centuries from now.

With '*Something to Hold On*', Khedri draws the viewer into a sombre, breathtaking space of reflection in which the deep-rooted desire to hold on to that which is already lost cannot be silenced. She has managed to portray this with artisanal craftsmanship, conceptual depth and raw emotional honesty. The artistic talent demonstrated here deserves recognition, encouragement and support for further development. The jury is therefore delighted to announce Kimia Khedri as the winner of the Jan Roëde Award 2026.

Huub van Wersch,
jury chairman

The Hague, 6 July 2026

The Jan Roëde Award 2026 consists of a sum of €3,000, intended as a donation of support to the artistic practice of the laureate. A certificate will also be presented to the laureate. The Jan Roëde Foundation will highlight the award ceremony and the artist who won the prize on its website (www.janroede.nl).